

Session 15: The Order of Public Worship

Key Takeaways

- We can infer that, in public gatherings, the Corinthians were all speaking in tongues at once because we see Paul instructing them to speak one at a time and limit the overall number of speakers.
- Four common approaches to interpreting 1 Corinthians 14:34-35 are: a subordinationist reading, a cultural reading, reading it as an interpolation, or reading it as a disagreement with the Corinthians.

1 Corinthians 14:29-36

How does Paul frame the bringing of prophetic words in 1 Corinthians 14:29-33? The spirits of the prophets are subject to the control of the prophets—not ecstatic experiences. There is a sense of control here.

Note that the transition from verses 33-34 is interpreted differently in different versions of the Bible. The NIV keeps the phrase, “as in all the congregations of the Lord’s people” as the end of the section on tongues and prophecy and not as the beginning of the section on women in verse 34.

This is not the case in all translations. NRSV begins the section on women with 33b and the phrase “as in all the churches of the saints” but places the whole women section ending at verse 36 in parentheses, presumably indicating an interpolation. ESV simply begins the section on women with 33b.

Differing Interpretations

There are various readings of these verses on women, and as with the passage in 1 Corinthians 11:2-16, we see a similar pattern.

1. A subordinationist reading
2. A cultural reading
3. An interpolation
4. A disagreement with the Corinthians

Subordination or Cultural Command?

In the past, these verses have been used to argue literally for the silencing of women in the congregation, and it would have been common in the past to find commentators interpreting this as a straightforwardly subordinationist text.

Others argue that this is a contextual command about some talkative married women and doesn’t apply to all the women in Paul’s churches. In other words, they were being rude. They argue that married women would

have been sectioned off in the assembly, but instead of listening are chatting during the service, so they should be quiet and ask their husbands at home.

Paul uses the term “to learn” in verse 35, *μανθάνω* (Greek: *manthanó*), which some people see in a positive light. Paul wants them to learn.

However, the language is strong here. In verse 34, Paul uses the word *sigao* (Greek: *σιγάω*—to keep silent, not permitted to speak as the Law says) and, in 35, *aischros* (Greek: *αἰσχρός*—it is shameful, disgraceful; this is the same word we find in 1 Corinthians 11:6 about cutting her hair).

Interpolation

Many people think this little section is an interpolation, partly because it doesn’t fit very well with what we read before and after. Philip Payne argues for this and then makes the points that this is something Paul would disagree with (Payne, 2009).

A Disagreement With the Corinthians

Kirk MacGregor argues that it is an example of a quotation-refutation device. Philip Payne argues against him. The debate can be found here.

- MacGregor, Kirk (2018). [“1 Corinthians 14:33b-38 as a Pauline Quotation-Refutation Device.”](#) Priscilla Papers.
- Payne, Philip B. (2019). [“Is 1 Corinthians 14:34-35 a Marginal Comment or a Quotation? A Response to Kirk MacGregor.”](#) Priscilla Papers.

MacGregor argues “that 1 Corinthians 14:33b-38 is best understood as Paul’s quotation and subsequent refutation of the Corinthian men’s position that women ought to be silent in the assemblies, which originated in the Judaizing faction of the church” (MacGregor, 2018).

He argues that the text is authentic based on the early manuscripts.

Debate centers on a little symbol in an ancient manuscript called the Codex Vaticanus. This symbol is called the distigme-obelos and can be seen in the text—two dots and a bar. It can signify that this text is a variant and so there are those that claim the scribe knew that this was an interpolation. For this argument see Philip Payne (2017), “Vaticanus Distigme-obelos Symbols Marked Added Text.”

MacGregor disagrees with the interpolation theory. His proposal is that the quotation-refutation device begins in 33b. He describes it as follows:

“33 For God is not of disorder but of peace. As (*Hōs*) in all the assemblies of the saints, 34 the women should keep silent in the assemblies; for they (*autais*, fem. pl.) are not permitted to speak, but should be in submission, just as the Law says. 35 But if they desire to learn anything, let them ask their own husbands at home; for it is shameful for women to speak in an assembly. 36 Or (*ē*) did the word of God originate with you (*hymas*, pl.), or (*ēhymas monous*, masc. pl.) has it come? 37 If anyone seems to be a prophet or

spiritual, let that one recognize that what I write to you (pl.) is a commandment of the Lord; 38 but if anyone disregards this, let that one be disregarded.”

MacGregor, Kirk (2018). [*“1 Corinthians 14:33b-38 as a Pauline Quotation-Refutation Device.”*](#) Priscilla Papers.

Verse 36 begins with *ē* (‘eh’), which has caused quite a bit of controversy. It means “or/than/either” or “hey/now!” It can function as a marker of an alternative, or a disjunctive particle signalling a change of tack.

It introduces a rhetorical question. What is it? What is Paul rebuking them for exactly?

“Paul introduces both rhetorical questions in v. 36 with *ē*, which he did six times elsewhere in 1 Corinthians to argue against the Corinthians’ position (1:13; 6:16; 9:6, 8, 10; 11:22) and five times to argue against a Corinthian deed (6:2; 9, 19; 10:22; 11:13).”

MacGregor, Kirk (2018). [*“1 Corinthians 14:33b-38 as a Pauline Quotation-Refutation Device.”*](#) Priscilla Papers.

Paul is rebuking the men in verse 36, not the women. If he had been rebuking the women only it would have taken a feminine form, *monas*.

“Far from attempting to silence women, therefore, Paul was rebuking the Corinthian men for prohibiting women from speaking in the assemblies, as he regarded such a restriction as tantamount to alleging that the Word of God belonged properly to the men and merely derivatively to any woman who was married to one of them. Paul summarily exposed the absurdity of this allegation with each part of the rhetorical question, whose form (not to mention the context) required a negative answer to each part. Obviously the Word of God neither originated with men nor has come only to men; hence it is ridiculous, and contrary to the character of the Gospel, to act as though the Word belonged properly to men by disallowing women from discoursing about it or asking questions about it in church. For these reasons, the preceding thought-unit is shown not to belong to Paul, but is rather Paul’s quotation of the Corinthians’ position from the letter they had previously sent him, his response to which letter constituted in large part the purpose of 1 Corinthians. This conclusion explains perfectly the paragraph breaks in our translation (*hōs* and *ē*), as Paul would clearly compose two shifts in thought when alternating from his own counsel to the position of the Corinthians back to his own counsel again. Hence Payne’s complaint that ‘[n]one of the other Corinthian quotations Paul refutes are nearly this long’ has no purchase; the paragraph breaks make clear that vv. 33b-35 are a separate thought-unit. Likewise, the shift of vv. 33b-35 is apparent by its interrupting the chiasm spanning vv. 26-40: A (v. 26), B (vv. 27-28), C (vv. 28-30), D (v. 33a), vv. 33b-35 (not part of the chiasm), C’ (vv. 36-38), B’ (v. 39), A’ (v. 40). Through this interruption, Paul makes it quite clear that vv. 33b-35 do not represent his thoughts, as opposed to his thoughts throughout the chiasm. Contrary to Payne’s objection that nothing in vv. 36-38 requires that it refutes vv. 34-35 if these verses were authentic, the *ē*, the *hymas monous* and its implications, and the two-part rhetorical question cumulatively require that v. 36 begins a thought-unit refuting vv. 33b-35.”

MacGregor, Kirk (2018). [*“1 Corinthians 14:33b-38 as a Pauline Quotation-Refutation Device.”*](#) Priscilla Papers.

Reflection Question

Which of the four interpretations of 1 Corinthians 14:34-35 have you heard before? Which interpretation do you find the most plausible and why?